were concerned, it was just another border incident that involved the Assam Rifles that functioned under the MEA.

Thimayya usually went to his official residence, White Gates, for lunch on Fridays. As he gathered his cap and cane, there was a knock on the door and the Director, Military Intelligence, Brigadier Prem Bhagat, walked into the army chief's office. Without any preamble, Bhagat told Thimayya that the joint secretary in the Ministry of Defence, H. C. Sarin, had just briefed him on the prime minister's statement in Parliament. 'Nehru has finally told Parliament the truth about the northern border. He spoke at length about the National Highway G219 and the loss of the Aksai Chin. He then spoke of both the Khenzemane and Longju incident.'

'It had to happen… I'm surprised it took so long for the press to realize everything isn't quite *bhai bhai* with the Chinese,' said Thimayya, shaking his head.

'There's something else…' Bhagat hesitated, not quite sure if Thimayya was already in on the decision. 'The prime minister has announced that as of today the entire border in NEFA with China is henceforth the army's responsibility.'

The usually calm and unflappable Thimayya now stared at Bhagat, not quite sure if he had heard him correctly. He moved back to his desk and sat down slowly. 'What else did Sarin say?' he asked incredulously.

'Nothing more, really. From his demeanour I gathered the Ministry of Defence had no idea this was coming. If Mr Krishna Menon was consulted by the prime minister, he certainly did not inform anybody else in the ministry.'

After Bhagat left the room, Thimayya smashed his fist on the table in frustration. The prime minister had rarely asked for the army's advice on Tibet and China, but whenever he had had the opportunity, Thimayya had repeatedly tried to impress upon Nehru the futility of trying to take on China in the current state of unpreparedness that the army found itself in. Even though the prime minister had himself commissioned the Himmatsinhji and Kulwant Singh Committees to give their assessment, most of their recommendations had largely been ignored. Now, with not even one soldier in NEFA and just a single infantry battalion in Ladakh, Nehru was handing over a terrible situation to the army. Worse, by announcing in Parliament that the army was now in charge, the carefully orchestrated border moves by the police and Assam Rifles were history.